

High Holidays and Beyond

Inclusive Congregation Guide

Prepared by

Ruderman Chabad Inclusion Initiative

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More Than Inclusion

“And You Shall Love Your Fellow as Yourself”¹

“He commanded us to love one another even as we love ourselves, and that my compassion and love for my fellow (-man) be as my compassion and love for myself with respect to his money, his person, and to whatever he possesses or desires. Whatever I wish for myself, I am to wish likewise for him; and whatever is hateful unto me or to whoever is attached to me, is likewise hateful unto me, with respect to him.”

*Rambam (Maimonides)*²

The relationship between Judaism and disability is rooted in *Ahavat Yisrael*, the love of fellow Jews.

Each and every one of us is imbued with a *neshama*, a G-dly soul, and because of that, we each have the responsibility to treat one another with respect and love. The Alter Rebbe said, ‘You shall love your fellow as yourself,’ with regard to every Jew both great and small — in spiritual stature. He reminded us that our souls are actually all equal; and not only equal yet separate, but, furthermore, they all have one Father — one source, and within their source they all comprise one entity.³ The mitzvah of *Ahavat Yisrael* is to love another Jew simply because he or she is a Jew.

With the Chasidic perspective in mind, we must make certain that no Jew with a disability and/or a mental health condition is ever regarded or treated as less than one who does not have a disability or mental health condition. *Ahavat Yisrael* unifies us.

Yet we are also different from one another. The Mishna Sanhedrin (4:5) informs our perspective on *Ahavat Yisrael* in that we respect one another for our unique qualities:

A human being mints many coins from the same mold but the Holy One, blessed be God, strikes us all from the mold of the first human and each one of us is unique. Therefore, every single person is obligated to say, 'The world was created for my sake.

Honoring one another’s individual contributions, strengths and qualities is necessary in order to achieve a community where every Jew belongs. The Rebbe, of righteous memory, provided an analogy: In a *Sefer Torah*, each letter has its individual characteristics. Each letter must be completely surrounded by blank parchment and no two letters may be touching. However, even if just one letter is missing, the entire *Sefer Torah* is rendered invalid.⁴ Who we are as a Jewish community depends on every Jew being part of the community. We are not whole until all of us belong.

Our community is not complete without each Jew participating. A Jew must feel like “half a shekel,” his other half being every other Jew.⁵

Ahavat Yisrael also requires that we do not label people by diagnosis, or terms such as “high or low functioning,” and “special needs” because they highlight what a person cannot do rather than tell us what a person can do. Instead of focusing on the disability, we can begin to learn what an individual’s unique gifts are, when they may need support, and what is important to them as a member of the Jewish community. Language matters as it affects how we regard others. (See Person-First Language in this Guide).

The Rebbe spoke about *Ahavat Yisrael* and people with disabilities. In his letters, the Rebbe firmly articulated that special education curriculum for Jewish students with disabilities include Jewish instruction.

In 1989, when the family of an autistic child came to see him during his Sunday distribution of dollar bills to be given to charity, the Rebbe emphasized that strengthening the child's Jewish identity be a top priority. [6](#)

"Does he have a *tzedaka* (charity) box in his room?" the Rebbe asked the parents of the young autistic man. He suggested that they give him a *tzedaka* box for his room so others could give to charity.

The Rebbe observed that while, perhaps as a function of autism, their son may not relate well to other people, he was in a relationship with G-d, perhaps even more so than someone without autism. In a second visit two years later, the parents joyfully told the Rebbe that their son was now *davening* quite proficiently in his own way. The Rebbe encouraged the parents to give their son the opportunity to nourish his *neshama*.

Dr. Robert Wilkes, director of the Child Development Center at the Coney Island Hospital, asked the Rebbe to comment on establishing a Jewish residential home for people with disabilities. He expanded on the idea even more. In one of the letters, the Rebbe wrote, "If the child is involved in Jewish education and activities and not in some general and peripheral way, but in a regular and tangible way, such as in the actual performance of *mitzvot*, customs and traditions, it would give him a sense of belonging and attachment, and a firm anchor to hold on to, whether consciously or subconsciously."

What Can I Do to Include People With Disabilities?

Start by examining your own attitudes and behavior as you prepare for *Rosh Hashanah* and *Yom Kippur*. Do you inadvertently or unintentionally regard people with disabilities as “them” while you see yourself as part of “us?” Do you stop short of breaking down barriers to full participation because you don’t know how or because you might make a mistake? Do you regard people with disabilities as *mitzvah* or *chesed* projects? Remember that people with disabilities can certainly perform *mitzvot*, like anyone else.

***Ahavat Yisrael* means that all of us belong.** We are each a part of the Jewish community. If it is important to you, then it is most likely important to someone who has a disability. Our

community can no longer make decisions about when, how and where people get to participate or with whom. And the first step is to eliminate “them” and “us” attitudes.

We do not do things **for** people with disabilities. We do things **with** people with disabilities. Inclusion is not something superficial that we “do.” Inclusion is who we are as Jews, as holy congregations, as G-d’s partners. True inclusion means that we regard others with dignity, respect and a genuine belief that each one of us, without regard to ability, is responsible to participate in this sacred partnership. Inclusion is achieved when people know that they **BELONG**.

The *High Holidays and Beyond Inclusive Congregations Guide* provides practical ideas you can incorporate into your High Holiday rituals, services and celebrations. While we always want to do the right thing, sometimes we need a little guidance, some creativity and resources to ensure that we are doing that right thing!

This guide is divided into several sections. The first section will help you and your community weave concepts and practical ideas into your High Holiday observances. The second section offers suggestions for Jewish Disability Awareness and Inclusion Month (JDAIM) in February. Planning for JDAIM can start right after the holidays. Following that is a section of practical ideas you can implement immediately. Finally, there is a commitment page for you and your congregation to complete as you enter the new year!

Ahavat Yisrael extends to all Jews, regardless of ability or disability. Each one of us has the capacity for love of our fellow Jews.

B’hatzlacha!

The Ruderman Chabad Inclusion Initiative Team

1 *Vayikra* 19:18.

2. *Sefer HaMitzvot*, Positive *Mitzvah* No. 206. See also *Chinuch*, *Mitzvah* 243. From <http://www.chabad.org/2312296>

3. A commentary on *Tanya* printed by Kehot Publishing Society, Brooklyn 5753, Vol. I, pp. 421-423. (The small type indicates commentary compiled from the Rebbe’s teachings by Rabbi Rabbi Yosef Wineberg in *Lessons In Tanya*.)

4. *Likkutei Sichos*, Vol. 24, p. 583; Vol. 20, p. 567.

5. *Likkutei Sichos*, Vol. 30, p. 189.

6. The Rebbe’s Perspective. www.Chabad.org/inclusion for entire videos, letters and more on The Rebbe’s perspective.

This is meant to be a resource guide. Every person, community and experience is unique. We encourage you to inquire with your rabbi for *halachic* considerations.

Inclusion, Belonging and the High Holidays

Many rabbis speak about inclusion from the pulpit. Some deliver a full sermon about inclusion through reflections of the *parshah*, a summary of congregational activities throughout the year, or create an opportunity to talk about it at other points in the service. Here are just some ideas:

Sermon Ideas:

- We are Not Your *Mitzvah* Project: Perspectives on Participation from People with Disabilities
- How Do We Welcome the Stranger?
- Biblical and Historical Perspectives on Disability Inclusion
- Presenting a Challenge to the Congregation: What is Your Role in Welcoming People with Disabilities?
- Inclusion: What is it and How Can We Achieve It?
- Creating a Roadmap for Inclusion: Why? How? When?
- Disability is Normal and Affects Us All
- The Year Ahead: How Our Congregation Supports People with Disabilities in Congregational Life Today and Opportunities for Tomorrow
- The Americans with Disabilities Act—Civil Rights and Moral Mandate

Engage the congregation during the Yom Kippur afternoon recess. Offer a “Food for Thought” program about an aspect of belonging, share a Torah message, convene a panel of inclusion committee members, people with disabilities and family members to lead a discussion on inclusion. Topics could include:

- Personal stories about why inclusion is important
- Topics on disability inclusion as social justice
- Trends in employment and housing initiatives
- People with Disabilities in the *Tanakh*: Contributions, Strengths and Gifts
- Discussion on how the synagogue can support life cycle events for people with disabilities. Include people with disabilities.
- Discussion on inclusive supports for students with disabilities in pre-school, religious school, confirmation, *bar* or *bat mitzvah* and youth groups.
- What do the Torah and the commentators say about inclusion?

Before the high holidays offer tours of the synagogue to people who are new or visiting so they can become familiar and comfortable to *daven* there. They can see and touch unfamiliar items, explore the *machzor*, stand on the *bimah*, hold the *Torah*, and find a seat where they will be comfortable sitting. Familiarity can help ease some anxiety about a new situation.

The easiest thing you can do is to announce page numbers often. Describe the *sefarim* by color and size, in addition to name.

Ask people with disabilities ahead of time to participate in leading prayers during the service. Honor them with *aliyot* and practice the *b'rachot* with them. Ask people with disabilities and

their family members to give a *d'var Torah*, recite the *Torah* or *Haftarah b'rachot* and recite the *Kiddush*.

If your *bimah* is not accessible, move it to the main level of the sanctuary so the *Torah* itself is accessible to all.

Train ushers to welcome and seat people with disabilities. Make sure they know where assistive listening devices and large print prayer books are located.

Do not create a separate section for people with disabilities to sit unless they use a sign language interpreter. In that case, seat them in the front row so they have access to the interpreter. Remember that people who use mobility devices may want to sit with friends or family.

During the month of *Elul* or the Days of Awe, incorporate inclusion in *Torah* study. *Parshat Nitzavim* is a powerful and meaningful text to study. It's a reminder that we all stood together to make the covenant with G-d. What does that mean as modern day Jews? How does that inform our congregational culture?

On days one can travel, lack of transportation is a tremendous barrier. Purchase ride vouchers from your community's accessible public transportation provider so people with disabilities who use that service can join. Volunteer drivers can assist in providing transportation, too! Finally, designate additional accessible parking spaces, and offer valet parking so family members can enter the building with their loved ones who have a disability.

Use social media to promote inclusion. Post your events. Quote text that resonates with Jewish values about belonging and inclusion. Record a short *d'var Torah* about inclusion for YouTube.

Provide *machzorim* and *chumashim* in accessible format (i.e. Braille, large print, audio versions).

Make your services accessible to people who have diverse sensory needs, such as sign language interpretation (set seats aside so those worshipers can see the interpreter clearly) and picture schedules of the service order. Include the start and ending times of services, the prayer order and the location of restrooms and drinking fountains in your service handout.

Make your sanctuary fragrance free so that people with extreme chemical sensitivity do not have severe reactions. Publicize this in your High Holiday mailings, on your website, and on tickets if you use them.

Make sure all lights are working and that there is plenty of light in the sanctuary for people who have low vision.

Start each service with the opportunity for congregants to turn to their neighbors and introduce themselves. Make sure that every person has someone with whom to share this greeting.

Plan for the New Year

- Start your Inclusion Committee or expand membership of an existing one.
- Reactivate your committee and review the charter or mission to determine what you have accomplished thus far. Make sure that people with disabilities are active members and leaders. Promote the committee from your *bimah*, social media, and website.
- As you thank your lay leaders and committee members during services, you can indicate what changes to the service, the physical plant, or programming are results of the inclusion initiative.
- Identify obstacles to participation within the organization. Examine:
 - Architectural barriers
 - Communication barriers
 - Attitudinal barriers
- What does your organizational mission statement say about inclusion? Charge your Inclusion Committee to review the congregation's mission statement and advise changes to advance inclusion.
- Promote inclusion and belonging. Every time you advertise an organizational event or program, include an accessibility statement (Examples of accessibility statements are in this Guide). Include a simple statement on all of your printed materials and website that support inclusion of people with disabilities.
- Post Braille signage on elevators, room and directional signs.
- Look at where the *mezuzot* are placed to determine whether someone who uses a wheelchair can reach it. They should be placed on the lower portion of the top one-third of the door frame.
- Start an inclusion or accessibility fund to help provide money for accommodations, modifications and accessible transportation.
- Assess each of the programming areas as well as architecture to identify barriers to inclusion. Use these assessments to set priorities and goals for inclusion in your organization.
- Write a monthly column for the bulletin on different aspects of inclusion in your congregation.
- Use language that promotes respect and dignity. For example, Sam is not handicapped or disabled. Sam is a person with a disability. Using Person First language is respectful and does not define a person by their disability, rather, having a disability is just one aspect of a person.

For people who use Identity-First language, (Alyssa is autistic or David is Deaf), be respectful of that as well. However, not describing someone by way of a diagnosis is the first step to seeing them as someone who has hopes, dreams, interests, skills, gifts, talents and interests like anyone else.
- Feeling that one belongs also means that people with disabilities contribute to the well-being of the congregation and community. How are people included in leadership roles, the board, and committees, leading and participating in services? Are people with disabilities employed at your congregation?

Plan Ahead for Jewish Disability Awareness and Inclusion Month (JDAIM)

February is Jewish Disability Awareness and Inclusion Month (JDAIM). Planning can start right after the High Holidays. Here are some suggestions for activities. You don't have to wait for February to incorporate these ideas. They can highlight belonging and support your vision all year long!

<https://www.facebook.com/JewishDisabilityAwarenessMonth>. For information and a free guide for JDAIM visit www.JDAIM.org.

- Host a congregational Shabbat dinner to kick-off JDAIM. Invite all members of your congregation, as well as other members of the Jewish community to join you. Put requests for accommodations on the invitation. If someone requests that food be cut, do that in the kitchen, not in the dining area. Continue the Shabbat celebration with a unique *Erev Shabbat* service recognizing that we are all created in the Divine Image—*B'zelem Elokim*. **Do not create a separate dinner or service for people with disabilities.** The purpose is to come together for Shabbat and raise awareness about inclusion and belonging among the entire community.
- Host a congregational *Havdallah* service with activities. Advertise this to your entire community, and encourage people with disabilities and their families to attend. The music and the scents of *Havdallah* provide a beautiful setting for art activities, games and stories. This should be open for all people to attend and not a separate service.
- Integrate Jewish Disability Awareness and Inclusion Month into other activities:
 - The youth group can provide afternoon activities for children with disabilities so parents and siblings have time together.
 - The Men's Club can sponsor a breakfast and invite a speaker from the community to talk about disability services (such as training service dogs).
 - Coordinate a program for parents of children with disabilities to bring them together and minimize isolation. Invite a speaker from Jewish Family Services to lead a parent education group. Provide child care.
 - Organize a program for siblings, such as SibShops, or invite a family life educator to come talk about sibling needs.
 - *Torah* Study can include other citations in our text that help us wrestle with inclusion.
 - Lunch and Learn following *davening* or on Sunday afternoon brings people together to process what they have learned and experienced from the weekend.
- Your Hebrew school can have age appropriate programming for students focused on the concept of *B'zelem Elokim*. Read books and stories written by or about children with a diverse range of abilities. See the list at the end of this Guide for book ideas. Prepare teachers to try a different teaching strategy to engage all learners. Invite parents of students who have disabilities to come to class and share their family's story.
- Be responsive to concerns expressed by people with disabilities and their families. Is there something that would be appropriate to address with programming during the month?

- This is a time for your organization to do some self-examination and self-discovery.

Relationships, Interactions and Presence

Adapted from Paraquad, St. Louis, MO

If the disability isn't relevant to the story or conversation, don't mention it.

A person is not his or her disability. Avoid describing a person as such. Don't present someone as "an epileptic" or "a post-polio." Instead, say "a person with epilepsy" or "a person who has had polio."

Don't act as a caregiver to people with disabilities. Ask if help is needed, but always wait until your offer is accepted. Listen to any instructions the person may have.

Leaning on a person's wheelchair is similar to leaning or hanging on a person. It is considered annoying and rude. The chair is part of a person's personal body space.

Share the same social courtesies with people with disabilities that you would share with anyone. If you shake hands with people you meet, offer your hand to everyone you meet, regardless of disability. If the person is unable to shake your hand, he or she will tell you.

When offering assistance to a person with a visual impairment, allow that person to take your arm. This will enable you to guide, rather than propel or lead the person. Use specific directions, such as "left in 100 feet" or "right in two yards" when directing a person with a visual impairment.

When planning events select an accessible spot. You wouldn't think of holding an event where other minorities could not attend, so don't exclude people with disabilities.

When speaking about people with disabilities, emphasize achievements, abilities and individual qualities. Portray them as they are in real life: parents, employees, business owners, etc.

When talking to a person who has a physical disability or a developmental disability, speak directly to that person. Don't speak through a companion or refer to him or her in the third person while in his or her presence. For people who communicate through sign language, speak to them, not to the interpreter.

To get the attention of a person who has a hearing loss, tap them on the shoulder or wave.

Look directly at the person and speak clearly, slowly and expressively to establish if they read lips. Not all people with hearing loss can read lips. Stay in the light and keep food, hands and other objects away from your mouth. Shouting won't help; written notes will. Use an interpreter, if necessary.

When talking to a person who uses a wheelchair, place yourself at eye level with that person. This will spare both of you a sore neck.

When greeting a person with a severe loss of vision, always identify yourself and others. For example, say, "On my right is John Smith." Remember to identify persons to whom you are speaking. Speak in a normal tone of voice and indicate when the conversation is over. Let them know when you move from one place to another.



Person First Language

Person First Language puts the person before the disability. It does not make the disability the first thing we know about that person. It simply tells us that he or she lives with a disability or uses a mobility device such as a wheelchair. Person First Language eliminates stereotypes and judgments about people who have disabilities. The language we use to describe a person who lives with a disability can shape our attitudes and perceptions about them.

Say This	Instead of
Sue has a disability	Sue is disabled, handicapped or differently abled
Jason uses a wheelchair	Jason is wheelchair bound, confined to a wheelchair
David has Down syndrome	David is a Downs kid
Aaron has an intellectual disability	Aaron is retarded or slow
Bridget has a physical disability	Bridget is crippled or physically challenged/disabled
Mark is hard of hearing	Mark is hearing impaired
Laura has a vision impairment	Laura is visually impaired
Toby has cerebral palsy	Toby is a victim of or stricken with cerebral palsy
Ann has a traumatic brain injury	Ann is brain damaged
Cheryl is unable to speak, uses a communication device	Cheryl is dumb or mute
People without disabilities	Normal, healthy, typical people

Disability VS. Special Needs: Although some organizations and educational programs use the term “special needs,” many people in the disability community feel that it generates pity and patronization and perpetuates the idea that people with disabilities require special care, special programs or special services which is often not true. The term “disability” is currently the preferred terminology and is a more authentic description without any judgment attached to it – positive or negative.

No Pity, No Heroism. The term disability is viewed as being non-judgmental and factual. Terms such as *nebach* connote pity and negative judgements.

Bottom Line: The evolution of language is constantly changing and being reevaluated. The bottom line is not to define a person by their disability unless that is how they choose to be defined. When in doubt, just ask.

Accessibility Request Statements

When you include an accommodation statement in all of your communications, you are demonstrating inclusion and welcoming. Your website, bulletins, weekly service programs, invitations to events and notices about programs should clearly state that your institution is accessible to people with disabilities.

Be sure that you have a contact person and a due date for requests in the event that you need to hire an interpreter, provide large print materials or ensure that someone who uses a wheelchair can sit with his or her family and friends at services or at an event.

The following examples support the Americans with Disabilities Act (ADA) and are provided by the Great Lakes ADA Center. These statements may be used to communicate that you are an inclusive organization and invite individuals to let you know about their need for special accommodations. The regulations implementing the ADA do not require specific language to be used in notifying the public. The obligation under the ADA is for entities covered to provide appropriate auxiliary aids and services in order to allow for individuals with disabilities to participate in the programs, activities or services.

Individuals with disabilities needing accommodations to participate in the meeting should contact _____ at 222-222-2222 or (email address) no later than _____.
(Make sure the request due date gives you reasonable amount of time to make the accommodation.

Accommodation requests by people with disabilities should be directed to _____ at 222-222-2222 or you can (email address) no later than _____.

Requests for sign language interpreter or materials in alternative format should be made no later than _____ to _____ at 222-222-2222 or email them at (email address).

Individuals with disabilities requiring additional services to participate in the service should call _____ 222-222-2222 by _____ or make the request by email (email address).

Additional language may be added to state that requests for accommodations made after the advertised date will be honored to the maximum extent feasible.

All Israel is Responsible for One Another

Commitment to Inclusion

Good intentions alone without action are without value for it is the action which makes the intentions so profound.

Chassidic Master Yehudi Hakadosh

Use this commitment form at board meetings, Torah study classes, and after every presentation on inclusion.

Ideas that will turn my good intentions into action are:

- 1.
- 2.
- 3.

I commit to take these actions:

- 1.
- 2.
- 3.

I will invite the following people to join me:

How do I think this will impact the lives of people with disabilities in my own community or organization? How will this impact the community or organization?

Dated:

Thank you for joining us to ensure that people with disabilities and their families find warmth and welcoming waiting for them.